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Anticipatory insights for "great resignation 2.0": a longitudinal study of voluntary turnover predictors and performance implications using the push-pull-mooring framework

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Abstract

Purpose – This study provides anticipatory insights for a likely "great resignation 2.0" by analyzing voluntary turnover predictors from two stakeholder perspectives: employees and human resource (HR) managers. Drawing on the push-pull-mooring (PPM) framework, it examines employee decision-making during the "great resignation" period that followed the COVID-19 pandemic.

Design/methodology/approach – In phase 1 of this three-phase longitudinal study, survey data from 236 junior and mid-level employees in Indian information technology (IT) and allied knowledge-based firms were analyzed to identify significant turnover predictors. The same cohort participated in two sequential phase 1 survey waves (45-item exploratory factor analysis (EFA) instrument followed by a 21-item baseline instrument). In phase 2, semi-structured interviews with 30 HR managers from the same organizations were conducted to compare managerial perceptions. Based on insights from both phases, pilot interventions were implemented. Phase 3, initiated one year after the implementation of the interventions, involved collecting follow-up data from 221 of the 236 employees who had participated in phase 1.

Findings – Phase 1 identified "pay and incentives", "training and continuous education", and "reward and recognition" as key predictors while "organizational culture" and "relationship with supervisor" remained non-significant. Phase 2 highlighted "nature of work", "job autonomy", "job prestige", and "work-life balance", revealing a perceptual gap in priorities between employees and their HR managers. Phase 3 data showed better alignment among the phase 1 predictors and greater explanation of the variance in voluntary turnover intention. Following the interventions, "relationship with supervisor" emerged as a significant factor, the influence of "pay and incentives" intensified while the influence of "reward and recognition" nearly halved.

Originality/value – The study contributes to the literature on strategic performance management by integrating turnover analysis with productivity concerns in a post-pandemic context. The findings have significant value in the current employment landscape as organizations are preparing for the "Great Resignation 2.0".

Keywords Voluntary turnover, Longitudinal study, Great resignation 2.0, Perceptual gap, Push-pull-mooring framework

Paper type Research article

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1. Introduction

The technology sector serves as a critical driver of economic growth, with IT services, including technology consulting and software development, expanding at twice the rate of the overall economy (World Bank, 2023). This rapid growth underscores the industry's pivotal role in enhancing productivity, generating employment opportunities, and fostering innovation across multiple sectors. However, a major challenge confronting this industry is high voluntary employee turnover. While industry growth is projected to reach 15% by 2031, the turnover rate in the sector is approaching 13% (Forbes, 2022). These trends suggest that turnover is likely to remain a persistent issue. Effectively addressing this challenge is essential to ensuring the continued contribution of the technology industry to global economic development, especially with the "great resignation 2.0" looming over the employment landscape in 2025 and beyond (Forbes, 2025).

However, to effectively prepare for the anticipated "great resignation 2.0", it is essential to critically examine the factors that contributed to the "great resignation". This phenomenon, which began in 2021, was marked by mass voluntary exits across industries (Patrick *et al.*, 2024a). In response to the crisis, the Indian IT sector was compelled to increase its hiring efforts by 52% and compensate for the talent shortage (Patrick *et al.*, 2024b). Basically, the COVID-19 pandemic triggered a fundamental shift in employees' priorities, a transformation that many employers failed to anticipate. Given the enduring psychosocial effects of the pandemic, this disruption has highlighted the need to reassess well-established turnover predictors and determine their relevance in the evolving occupational climate. Additionally, a comprehensive understanding of voluntary turnover necessitates an exploration of the contrasting perspectives of HR managers and employees (Basnyat and Clarence Lao, 2020). This potential misalignment may result in ineffective retention strategies, particularly if HR responses fail to reflect frontline realities. By analyzing these differing viewpoints, organizations can identify the perceptual gaps and implement targeted interventions to mitigate future turnover challenges.

Against this backdrop, the objective of the study is to examine and compare the divergent perceptions of HR managers and employees, thereby identifying gaps in their understanding of voluntary turnover following the "great resignation" phase. Using a longitudinal, mixed-methods approach, the study analyzes employee survey responses and HR manager interviews across three phases. In phase 1, significant turnover predictors were determined from a sample of 236 employees. In phase 2, insights were gathered from 30 HR managers to identify the perceptual gaps. The findings were systematically categorized using the PPM framework (Fu, 2011), which classifies turnover predictors into three categories: push factors, which drive employees away from their current organizations; pull factors, which attract employees to alternative employment opportunities; and mooring factors, which either facilitate or hinder employee mobility. Following this classification, targeted pilot interventions were made. For phase 3, data were collected again more than one year after the implementation of those interventions to gauge their efficacy.

This study makes significant contributions to the existing body of literature on voluntary turnover, particularly within the IT sector. First, it empirically validates the PPM framework in a high-turnover sector undergoing post-pandemic recalibration. Second, it highlights a significant perceptual gap between HR managers and employees, offering a novel perspective on why conventional retention strategies may fail. This approach addresses a critical gap in turnover research by underscoring the importance of aligning managerial perceptions with employees' lived experiences. Furthermore, the study presents actionable strategies to mitigate the identified misalignment, enabling organizations to refine their retention initiatives. By offering both diagnostic and strategic value, this study provides tailored HR policies to address the turnover risks associated with the anticipated "great resignation 2.0".

2. Literature review

2.1 Voluntary employee turnover

Employee turnover refers to the separation of an employee from an organization, which may occur voluntarily through resignation or involuntarily due to layoffs or dismissal. This study

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focuses specifically on voluntary employee turnover, which is often regarded as dysfunctional due to its negative impact on organizational performance (Park and Shaw, 2013, p. 269). The costs associated with voluntary turnover encompass several factors, including lost productivity and the expenses incurred from an employee's departure. Such expenses encompass recruitment, training, and the onboarding of a new hire (Li *et al.*, 2022). From a performance management perspective, voluntary turnover results in the erosion of accumulated knowledge and expertise as well as potential disruptions to social relationships which may hinder knowledge-sharing processes (Lee, 2018). Additionally, voluntary turnover can lead to adverse consequences such as the imitation of withdrawal behaviours by remaining employees, ultimately contributing to further turnover within the organization (Wang *et al.*, 2017; Porter and Rigby, 2021).

Voluntary turnover is influenced by a range of individual and organizational factors, including HR practices (Cristiani and Peiró, 2019). The content models of turnover suggest that undesirable job characteristics contribute to an employee's decision to leave (Zimmerman *et al.*, 2019). Additionally, factors related to Herzberg's dual-factor theory, such as compensation and rewards, leadership quality, trust and respect, challenging job demands, opportunities for career development, and overall job satisfaction play a significant role in turnover decisions (Booth and Hamer, 2007). However, individual and organizational factors do not function independently. As highlighted in theories of person-environment fit, job embeddedness, and work adjustment, the degree of compatibility between various aspects of the work environment as well as the reciprocal interactions between employees and organizations in meeting mutual expectations significantly influence an employee's intention to remain within an organization (Boon and Biron, 2016). Consequently, examining the causes of turnover beyond attitudinal variables may provide deeper insights into the underlying dynamics of employee retention.

High turnover rates often indicate suboptimal working conditions, below-market compensation, or inadequate employee training. Conversely, a low turnover rate suggests that employees feel valued, collaborate effectively, and experience job satisfaction (Huang *et al.*, 2021). HR managers actively implement strategies to mitigate voluntary turnover (Malik *et al.*, 2021). Nevertheless, turnover remains a significant challenge, particularly in the IT and IT-enabled services sectors, not only in India but globally. This ongoing issue has led to an investigation into the perceptual gap between HR managers and employees regarding the factors influencing turnover (De Gieter and Hofmans, 2015).

2.2 The PPM framework

The PPM framework was originally developed in migration theory (Moon, 1995) to explain individual decision-making in the context of relocation. It has since been extended to multiple domains, including organizational behaviour, employee mobility, and consumer switching behaviour (Bansal *et al.*, 2005). At its core, the PPM model posits that departure from a current situation is driven by three types of forces: push factors, pull factors, and mooring factors.

In the context of voluntary turnover, push factors are internal, often negative attributes of the current situation that drive individuals away—such as job dissatisfaction, lack of career growth, poor organizational culture, toxic work environments, or burnout (Maertz and Campion, 2004). Pull factors, on the other hand, refer to external attractions that draw individuals toward an alternative. Such factors encompass better compensation, more desirable roles, or improved work-life balance in another organization (Fu, 2011). Mooring factors are contextual or personal characteristics that either inhibit or facilitate movement. These include psychological attachment, social obligations, family concerns, or institutional constraints (Lee *et al.*, 1996).

The PPM framework enables a comparative understanding of how stakeholders perceive voluntary turnover. While employees might prioritize intrinsic push factors like poor leadership or a lack of autonomy, HR managers may focus more on external pull mechanisms

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such as industry competition or market-driven attrition (Hom *et al.*, 2012). This misalignment can result in retention strategies that are ineffective or overly generalized. Hence, applying the PPM model not only structures the conceptual analysis of turnover but also highlights perceptual gaps between stakeholder groups.

From a performance management perspective, PPM offers insight into the interplay between personal dissatisfaction and organizational systems. High push and pull pressures with weak mooring constraints increase turnover risk. They can destabilize team performance, affect client delivery, and diminish organizational learning (Haldorai *et al.*, 2019). By identifying which factors are most salient in particular contexts – e.g. whether "lack of recognition" (push) or "better salary" (pull) exerts more influence - organizations can adopt more targeted retention practices aligned with performance objectives.

The PPM framework provides both explanatory depth and practical utility for analyzing voluntary turnover. Its adaptability across cultural and sectoral contexts makes it especially relevant to the Indian IT and ITeS sectors, where socio-economic, psychological, and organizational forces converge to shape complex career decisions.

2.3 Hypotheses development

2.3.1 Nature of work. The nature of work refers to the specific duties and responsibilities assigned to an employee in their current role. It should align with the employee's professional goals, as job fit is considered a significant factor influencing voluntary turnover. Research suggests that as job demands and task interdependence increase, employees are more likely to experience burnout, which in turn, elevates turnover intentions (Jamal *et al.*, 2024). Furthermore, extant literature has shown that job-related experiences remain one of the fairly consistent antecedents of voluntary turnover decisions across organizational contexts (Hom *et al.*, 2017). Meta-analytic evidence also demonstrates that job dissatisfaction, poor role experiences, and unfavorable work characteristics significantly increase voluntary turnover intentions (Rubenstein *et al.*, 2018). On the other hand, the job embeddedness theory emphasizes the importance of alignment between an individual and their job in fostering organizational retention (Zhang *et al.*, 2012). Similarly, the job characteristics model highlights that job design elements - such as skill requirements, task identity, and task significance - contribute to employees' sense of meaningfulness and job performance (Han *et al.*, 2020). This relationship has become particularly salient in IT/ITeS industries where employees increasingly evaluate whether their roles provide meaningful work experiences and long-term career relevance. For instance, job-related experiences can significantly influence turnover decisions among employees in the internet sector (Chang *et al.*, 2023). Consequently, nature of work can serve as a predictor of voluntary turnover, with greater job fit being associated with lower turnover rates.

H1. There is a negative relationship between perceived good job fit and voluntary turnover intention.

2.3.2 Pay and incentives. Pay and incentives refer to the monetary compensation provided to employees, including a structured pay scale and performance-based bonuses. According to the met expectations model, employees develop expectations regarding their compensation. When these expectations are not met, dissatisfaction and turnover may result (Ababneh, 2016). Financial compensation and incentives function as hygiene factors, playing a critical role in maintaining a baseline level of job satisfaction (de Waal and Jansen, 2013). Additionally, appropriate monetary benefits in the form of retention bonuses, during organizational transitions such as mergers have been shown to delay employee departures and mitigate the negative impact of such events (Ng *et al.*, 2019). Thus, competitive compensation is fundamental to an employee's decision to remain within an organization. Employees also engage in social comparisons, assessing their compensation relative to colleagues both within and outside the organization (Gartenberg and Wulf, 2017).

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Such compensation comparisons become critical when employees perceive limited future financial growth within their current organizations. Conversely, salary growth and promotion opportunities significantly reduce voluntary turnover by strengthening employees' perceived long-term value within the organization (Trevor *et al.*, 1997; Trevor and Nyberg, 2008). This is true within intra-organizational compensation structures (Shaw *et al.*, 1998) and across inter-organizational contexts (Rubenstein *et al.*, 2018). Hence, perceived inequities in pay and benefits may contribute to greater turnover intentions, prompting employees to seek better opportunities elsewhere (Alterman *et al.*, 2021).

H2. There is a negative relationship between perceived equities in pay and incentives and voluntary turnover intention.

2.3.3 Reward and recognition. In addition to financial compensation, employees seek non-financial rewards which can serve as positive reinforcements. Recognition and appreciation have been identified among the most frequently cited reasons employees choose to remain with organizations, highlighting the retention value of symbolic rewards beyond purely economic incentives (Hausknecht *et al.*, 2009). These non-monetary rewards contribute to employees' perceptions of distributive fairness and equity while simultaneously fulfilling needs related to esteem, competence, and professional growth (Arnold *et al.*, 2009). Recognition mechanisms also lead to increased intrinsic motivation, which has been shown to negatively correlate with burnout and turnover intention (Kim, 2018). Consequently, perceived fairness in non-financial rewards is expected to reduce voluntary turnover. On the other hand, the absence of recognition and appreciation may contribute to the phenomenon of quiet quitting where employees perform only the bare minimum role requirements. Such behaviour is characterized by psychological disengagement and reduced discretionary effort, ultimately increasing employees' intentions to quit the job altogether (Atiq *et al.*, 2025). Furthermore, non-financial rewards are an integral component of total rewards which have been positively associated with employee engagement and retention (Rai *et al.*, 2019). They act as protective resources in stressful work situations (Stocker *et al.*, 2019) and strengthen organizational attachment, thereby reducing voluntary turnover intention (Allen *et al.*, 2003).

H3. There is a negative relationship between perceived fairness in reward and recognition and voluntary turnover intention.

2.3.4 Organizational culture. Another significant factor influencing turnover intention is organizational culture. Organizational culture encompasses the shared norms, values, symbols, and narratives that define the collective way of functioning within an organization (Warrick, 2017). As a consistent and observable pattern of behaviours, organizational culture plays a crucial role in shaping employee attitudes and actions (Hogan and Coote, 2014). According to job embeddedness theory, alignment between an individual's values and organizational culture enhances job fit. This, in turn, increases the likelihood of employee retention (Kiazad *et al.*, 2015). Beyond value congruence, supportive organizational cultures also strengthen employee engagement, organizational commitment, and perceptions of employer attractiveness, leading to reduced voluntary turnover intention (Nguyen and Nguyen, 2023; Sheridan, 1992). On the contrary, dysfunctional cultural environments may accelerate withdrawal cognitions by weakening employees' emotional attachment to the organization (Maertz *et al.*, 2007). Accordingly, organizational cultures that foster value congruence, supportive relationships, and psychological attachment are expected to weaken employees' intentions to quit voluntarily.

H4. There is a negative relationship between positive perceptions of organizational culture and voluntary turnover intention.

2.3.5 Job autonomy. Job autonomy refers to an employee's perceived level of control over crafting various aspects of their work environment. Such aspects include task sequencing, pacing, procedural choices, scheduling, and coordination (Wrzesniewski and Dutton, 2001).

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It plays a particularly significant role in the IT sector where autonomy among knowledge workers is closely linked to workplace well-being (Joo *et al.*, 2016). Providing employees with autonomy enables them to structure their tasks according to their preferences, thereby reducing workload-related stress and influencing perceptions of job demands and turnover intention (Ahuja *et al.*, 2007). According to the job characteristics model, greater autonomy fosters positive attitudes toward work, enhancing job satisfaction and organizational commitment (Gillet and Vandenberghe, 2014). Moreover, in increasingly flexible and technology-driven work environments, autonomy has become even more salient as employees seek greater control over how, when, and where work is performed (Kellogg *et al.*, 2020). Recent empirical evidence suggests that the COVID-19 pandemic and the growing integration of artificial intelligence (AI) have reconfigured traditional autonomy structures by increasing algorithmic oversight, workload uncertainty, and burnout, thereby intensifying employees' turnover intention (Jamal *et al.*, 2024; Xavier and Korunka, 2025). Thus, greater perceived job autonomy may function as an important retention mechanism by strengthening employees' sense of control, reducing workplace strain, and limiting withdrawal cognitions.

H5. There is a negative relationship between perceived greater job autonomy and voluntary turnover intention.

2.3.6 Relationship with supervisor. Leadership and immediate supervision play a crucial role in shaping an employee's intention to remain within an organization (Maertz *et al.*, 2007). Effective leadership influences employees' job performance by providing clear direction, necessary resources, and supportive behaviours (Kim *et al.*, 2018). Additionally, leaders may form in-groups and out-groups wherein in-group members develop stronger relationships with their leaders and benefit from greater information and resource sharing (Raelin, 2003). This relational dynamic has been explained adequately through the leader-member exchange theory, which suggests that high-quality supervisor-subordinate relationships foster trust, mutual obligation, and stronger organizational attachment (Graen and Uhl-Bien, 1995). According to this theory, high-quality leader-member relationships strengthen perceived organizational support and significantly reduce employee turnover intention (Huang *et al.*, 2021). The job embeddedness theory also postulates that a positive relationship with a supervisor serves as a key organizational attachment factor, aligning with the second dimension of job embeddedness (Ampofo *et al.*, 2017). Such relationships have been linked to favourable employee outcomes, including increased employee voice and engagement (Wang *et al.*, 2022). Additionally, supervisor appreciation functions as a critical psychological resource by buffering workplace stressors and improving employee well-being over time (Stocker *et al.*, 2019). As a result, supportive supervisor relationships may reduce voluntary turnover intention by strengthening employees' psychological attachment to the organization.

H6. There is a negative relationship between perceived positive employee-supervisor relationship and voluntary turnover intention.

2.3.7 External job prestige. Prestige, in this context, refers to the perceived social status of a job position as recognized by external individuals (Fuller *et al.*, 2006). Perceived external prestige can influence an employee's decision to remain within an organization because employees often derive social validation and professional status from being associated with organizations that are viewed favourably by external stakeholders (Mignonac *et al.*, 2006). Such perceptions strengthen employees' affective commitment by reinforcing their sense of external recognition and professional self-worth (Carmeli, 2005). Similarly, research on employer branding suggests that positive organizational reputation strengthens organizational attractiveness and deepens employee attachment to the organization (Lievens and Slaughter, 2016). This enhanced organizational identification and psychological empowerment lead to reduced voluntary turnover intention (Akgunduz and Bardakoglu, 2017). Furthermore, according to the job embeddedness theory, the status of a job, particularly as perceived by family members, can serve as a strong attachment factor

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(Holtom and Darabi, 2018). Additionally, kinship factors have been identified as potential predictors of turnover (Hom *et al.*, 2012). This effect may be particularly pronounced in collectivist societies, such as India, where family influence plays a significant role in career-related decisions (Fouad *et al.*, 2015).

H7. There is a negative relationship between perceived external job prestige and voluntary turnover intention.

2.3.8 Work-life balance. Work-life balance is defined as an individual's "perception that work and non-work activities are compatible and contribute to personal growth in alignment with their current life priorities" (Kalliath and Brough, 2008). It encompasses the ability to allocate quality time to family and effectively manage work demands. Greater work-life balance aids in reducing stress, burnout, and role conflict (Wood *et al.*, 2020). As a result, work-life balance is a crucial determinant of voluntary turnover (Jackson and Fransman, 2018). For professionals in the IT sector, maintaining work-life balance can be particularly difficult. This issue arises from the very nature of information and communication technologies (ICTs) which provide both flexibility and continuous connectivity, often requiring employees to be available around the clock (Adisa *et al.*, 2017). These challenges have become even more pronounced in post-pandemic work environments, where remote and hybrid work arrangements offer greater flexibility while simultaneously blurring the boundaries between professional and personal lives (Shockley *et al.*, 2021). From a work design perspective, expectations of constant availability may spark emotional exhaustion and role conflict despite offering greater autonomy (Aleem *et al.*, 2023; Wang *et al.*, 2021). As hybrid work models continue to gain prominence across organizations, employees are more likely to evaluate employers based on their ability to support sustainable work-life integration (Junça Silva and Lopes, 2025). Consequently, poor work-life balance may intensify withdrawal cognition and increase voluntary turnover intention.

H8. There is a negative relationship between perceived greater work-life balance and voluntary turnover intention.

2.3.9 Training and continuous education. IT professionals are highly intrinsically motivated and prioritize skill development, often seeking projects that offer meaningful learning opportunities (Ahmed *et al.*, 2017). Additionally, continuous learning is essential in the IT sector due to the rapid evolution of required skills (London and Diamante, 2002). Since IT professionals are knowledge workers, their value within an organization is closely tied to their skill proficiency and adaptability (Garrick and Clegg, 2000). Consequently, a strong learning culture has been found to correlate with lower turnover intention (Lin and Huang, 2021). Also, organizations that promote competency development tend to strengthen long-term employability perceptions, which positively influence career commitment and retention decisions (De Vos *et al.*, 2011). Similarly, employer investments in training have been found to significantly reduce turnover intention by enhancing employees' perceptions of future career security and organizational support (Martini *et al.*, 2023). Therefore, organizations must offer continuous training and educational opportunities. Such initiatives not only enhance employees' competence but also signal that the organization values their professional development (Schmidt, 2007). Training and upskilling have become even more critical in the era of AI, where rapid technological disruption has accelerated skill obsolescence risks for middle-skilled employees (Chuang *et al.*, 2024). If they are to stay relevant in the long run then they need to reskill for the potential opportunities that are likely to be created in an AI-dominated workplace and upskill to offset for the job tasks that are likely to get fully automated with the advent of AI.

H9. There is a negative relationship between perceived greater opportunities for training and continuous education and voluntary turnover intention.

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3. Methodology

3.1 Design

This study employed a longitudinal, mixed-methods research design structured across three sequential phases. Central to this design is the application of the PPM framework, which helped categorize turnover predictors into push factors, pull factors, and mooring factors. The research is grounded in a paradigm that allows for methodological pluralism and emphasizes the practical resolution of real-world problems through both subjective and objective means (Nyein *et al.*, 2020). Ontologically, the study assumes that reality is complex and context-dependent as voluntary turnover is shaped by both individual perceptions and organizational structures. Epistemologically, the study acknowledges that knowledge is co-constructed through interaction with participants, and validated through triangulation across methods and stakeholder perspectives.

Phase 1 involved a quantitative survey of IT sector employees to establish a baseline understanding of voluntary turnover predictors post the "great resignation" period. Phase 2 employed a qualitative method through semi-structured interviews with HR managers, providing organizational insights and managerial perspectives. Based on the findings of the first two phases, targeted HR interventions were proposed. Phase 3 re-engaged with participants of the phase 1 employee cohort to evaluate the post-intervention impact on turnover predictors. This multi-method approach ensured both breadth and depth, combining statistical rigor with contextual richness.

The study involved adult working professionals and collected anonymized survey and interview data without any personally identifiable information. Participation was voluntary, informed consent was obtained prior to data collection, and participants were informed of their right to withdraw at any time. All data were stored securely on institutional systems accessible only to the research team. A purposive sampling strategy was employed to recruit participants across all three phases. Organizations were approached through academic–industry professional networks, alumni networks, and established HR contacts. For phase 1 and phase 3, HR representatives circulated the survey invitation internally to eligible employees. The research team did not receive employee lists and did not directly contact individual employees at any stage, thereby preserving anonymity and minimizing any potential coercion.

3.2 Phase 1: employee surveys

In phase 1, a 45-item research instrument was developed (see Appendix 1) through a structured adaptation process using Spector's (1985) Job Satisfaction Survey (JSS) and Schmidt's (2004) Job Training and Job Satisfaction Survey Technical Manual as theoretically grounded item banks rather than as complete scales. The JSS provided validated facet-level indicators of pay, promotion, contingent rewards, and operating conditions while Schmidt's instrument contributed theoretically aligned dimensions of supervision, nature of work performed, and training plus continuous education. In addition to items adapted from JSS and Schmidt (2004), several constructs were developed or refined to reflect contemporary IT and ITeS sector turnover dynamics in the post–"great resignation" context. Voluntary turnover intention items were grounded in classical turnover intention and withdrawal cognition models (Mobley *et al.*, 1978; Meyer and Allen, 1991; Tett and Meyer, 1993). Work–life balance indicators were informed by work–family conflict and work–family balance frameworks (Allen, 2001; Greenhaus and Beutell, 1985). Items capturing external job prestige and perceived alternative attractiveness were conceptually derived from employability and organizational identification research (Mael and Ashforth, 1992). Job autonomy–related indicators were grounded in the Job Characteristics Model (Hackman and Oldham, 1975). These theoretically anchored adaptations ensured that the instrument captured both established job satisfaction facets and contemporary predictors of voluntary turnover in knowledge-intensive organizational settings.

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A detailed item-to-construct mapping table is provided in Appendix 2. The appendix specifies for each item: a) original theoretical source, b) original construct, c) adapted wording for IT/ITeS context used in the present study, d) final construct classification in the present study, and e) retention or removal during EFA purification. All items were reviewed by five subject-matter experts in human resource management to establish content validity using item–objective congruence procedures (Turner and Carlson, 2003) before initiating data collection. Feedback led to minor contextual refinements (e.g. replacing generic organizational terminology with IT-specific phrasing), without altering the underlying theoretical meaning of the items. The survey used a five-point Likert scale (1 = "Strongly disagree" to 5 = "Strongly agree") to capture employees' perceptions of factors contributing to voluntary turnover (Carr *et al.*, 1996). While some constructs contained a relatively small number of items following EFA, the retained items demonstrated strong loadings and theoretical coherence, along with satisfactory reliability and Average Variance Extracted (AVE) thresholds. The choice to adapt theoretically grounded item banks rather than administer full-length standardized scales was deliberate. The present study aimed to model voluntary turnover intention within a multi-construct PPM framework rather than measure global job satisfaction. Administering full scales (e.g. comprehensive organizational culture or engagement inventories) would have substantially increased survey length and participant burden, potentially compromising data quality. This decision was in line with applied organizational research contexts where parsimonious yet psychometrically sound scales are preferable (DeVellis, 2017).

Phase 1 data collection was carried out between June 2022 and September 2022. A total of 288 survey responses were received from junior and mid-level employees working in IT and ITeS firms across major metropolitan cities in India. These participants were full-time employees, and had worked for a minimum of three months in their current organization. Of these 288 responses, 52 were excluded for a) being incomplete, b) being straight-lined or patterned responses, c) having implausibly short completion times. 236 complete and usable responses were retained after screening (response rate = 82%). Participants were primarily engineering graduates or postgraduates with an average tenure of 1.5 years in their current organizations. The demographic profile of the phase 1 participants has been detailed in Table 1. The survey was distributed electronically, ensuring geographic diversity while maintaining response integrity.

The survey data collected during phase 1 were analyzed using EFA for factor structure validation and linear regression for hypotheses testing. Phase 1 data were collected in two

Table 1. Demographic characteristics of the respondents (Phase 1)

Category	Value	% of total participants (N = 236)
Gender	Male	39% (n = 92)
	Female	61% (n = 144)
Age (in years)	≤25	23% (n = 54)
	25–35	54% (n = 128)
	≥35	23% (n = 54)
Monthly Income (in INR. 1k = 1,000)	≤20k	11% (n = 26)
	20k–30k	24% (n = 56)
	≥30k	65% (n = 154)
Experience in years (in current company)	≤1	22% (n = 53)
	1–3	43% (n = 101)
	3–5	23% (n = 54)
	≥5	12% (n = 28)

Source(s): Authors' own work

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sequential waves from the same cohort of 236 participants. In the first wave, responses to the full 45-item instrument were used for EFA to establish dimensional validity and refine the measurement structure. Based on EFA results, 21 items were retained across six constructs. In the second wave, the retained 21-item instrument was re-administered to the same participants prior to any intervention, and these responses were used for regression-based hypotheses testing.

3.3 Phase 2: HR manager interviews

Phase 2 employed a qualitative research design to gather managerial perspectives on voluntary turnover within the same IT and ITeS organizations that were sampled in phase 1. Semi-structured interviews were conducted with 30 HR managers from the phase 1 participating organizations, complementing the employee survey findings with organizational-level insights.

Participants were selected using purposive sampling to ensure that respondents held mid-to-senior level HR positions with direct experience in managing employee retention strategies. HR managers were selected based on the following criteria: (1) minimum five years of HR experience, (2) active involvement in retention, talent management, or workforce planning, (3) employment within IT/ITeS firms that had participated in phase 1. Recruitment occurred through direct outreach to organizational HR heads. Participation was voluntary. Prior to the interview, participants reviewed and agreed to an informed consent statement. Interviews were anonymized during transcription, and no identifiable organizational names are reported in this manuscript.

Phase 2 interviews were conducted between October 2022 and December 2022 through virtual conferencing platforms to accommodate geographic dispersion. Each interview lasted between 30 to 45 min and followed a semi-structured guide designed to allow flexibility while maintaining consistency across participants. The interview guide focused on the following key thematic areas: (1) HR managers' perceptions of voluntary turnover predictors, (2) organizational interventions aimed at mitigating turnover, (3) reflections on the impact of the "great resignation" phenomenon, and (4) anticipated challenges for workforce management over the next two years. Open-ended questions encouraged participants to elaborate on experiences, examples, and perceived misalignments between management actions and employee expectations. The textual data were analyzed using qualitative content analysis supported by text mining techniques in R programming.

3.4 Phase 3: longitudinal follow-up and post-intervention analysis

Phase 3 involved a longitudinal follow-up designed to assess changes after the implementation of HR interventions derived from the phase 1 and phase 2 findings. The primary objective was to evaluate the effectiveness of these interventions on voluntary turnover intention and predictor dynamics over time. The interventions implemented before phase 3 were structured pilot-level initiatives conducted in collaboration with participating organizational units rather than organization-wide policy reforms. Based on insights from phases 1 and 2, specific retention-oriented practices were recommended to HR representatives and team leaders. These recommendations were voluntarily adopted within selected teams that had participated in the earlier phases of the study. The implementation scope was therefore limited to participating units and should be interpreted as targeted pilot interventions rather than a firm-wide structural transformation.

The pilot interventions were implemented over an approximate 9–12 month period following completion of the phase 2 qualitative interviews. The longitudinal follow-up survey was administered in August 2024, approximately six months after the pilot interventions had been operational within participating units. This staggered timeline allowed sufficient exposure to intervention practices before reassessment. Implementation activities were coordinated through HR communication records, documented training schedules, and internal

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confirmation from participating units. However, these materials are organizationally confidential and therefore not publicly reproducible. Of the original 236 phase 1 respondents, 221 participated in the phase 3 follow-up survey, yielding a retention rate of 93.6% for longitudinal analysis. Attrition ($n = 15$) was attributable to job transitions, relocation, or non-response during the follow-up period. The follow-up survey utilized the same validated instrument that was employed in phase 1, thereby ensuring measurement consistency. The survey data collected during phase 3 were analyzed using linear regression for hypotheses testing. A detailed participant flow across all study phases is presented in Table 2, outlining initial survey distribution, usable responses, EFA retention, regression analysis, qualitative interviews, longitudinal follow-up, and participant attrition during phase 3 data collection.

4. Results

4.1 Phase 1: factor structure validation

An initial assessment of sampling adequacy produced a Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin (KMO) measure of 0.806, indicating good suitability for factor analysis (Hair *et al.*, 2006). The Bartlett's test of sphericity was significant ($p < 0.05$). Items with anti-image correlation values below the threshold of 0.5 were systematically removed to improve model fit (Hair *et al.*, 2014). Specifically, the items coded as VT4, VT6, VT8, NOF1, NOF2, NOF3, NOF4, RG1, WLB1, WLB2, WLB3, WLB4, PRS2, PRS3, PRS4, PIN3, and OGC2 were excluded following the first round of analysis.

An additional list of seven items out of the original 45 questionnaire items was discarded due to low communalities and inadequate factor loadings. The remaining items were regrouped and re-coded to ensure alignment with the theoretical constructs underpinning the hypotheses. Subsequent factor analysis yielded a 6-factor solution comprising 21 retained variables. The rotated component matrix along with corresponding factor loadings, Cronbach's alpha values, and AVE values, is presented in Appendix 3. The remaining items demonstrated strong loadings above the commonly accepted threshold of 0.7 (Hair *et al.*, 2017). Plus, the AVE values were greater than 0.5, confirming convergent validity (Hair *et al.*, 2019b). Cronbach's alpha values for all six constructs ranged from 0.78 to 0.85, reflecting

Table 2. Participant flow across phases

Stage	Description	*N*	Notes
Initial survey distribution	Survey distributed electronically to IT and ITeS employees across metropolitan Indian cities	288	Total number of survey responses received
Completed responses (Phase 1 – Instrument Development)	45-item instrument responses received	236	Usable responses retained after screening. Response rate – 82%
Exploratory Factor Analysis (EFA)	45 items analyzed	236	21 items retained post-EFA
Phase 1 – Regression and hypotheses testing (pre-intervention)	Composite scores computed from retained 21 items	236	Same participant pool; second survey wave for hypotheses testing
Phase 2 – HR manager interviews	Semi-structured interviews conducted	30	Separate stakeholder sample
Phase 3 – Longitudinal follow-up (post-intervention)	Follow-up employee survey on the retained 21 items	221	93.6% retention rate from phase 1
Phase 3 – Attrition	Non-response at follow-up	15	Due to job change, relocation, or non-response

Source(s): Authors' own work

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satisfactory to excellent internal consistency and acceptable reliability levels (Hair *et al.*, 2014). Overall, the factor structure was deemed robust, providing a solid foundation for subsequent hypotheses testing through regression analysis.

4.2 Phase 1: hypotheses testing

For hypotheses testing, the constructs: "nature of work" (H1), "job autonomy" (H5), "external job prestige" (H7), and "work-life balance" (H8) were not considered as the items for these constructs were dropped after EFA. Multiple regression analysis was employed to test the remaining hypotheses. The regression model demonstrated strong fit statistics: $R = 0.734$, $R^2 = 0.539$, and Adjusted $R^2 = 0.528$, indicating that approximately 52.8% of the variance in voluntary turnover intention was explained by the predictors. The detailed results of the hypotheses testing are presented in Table 3.

Among the hypotheses tested:

(1) H2 *("pay and incentives")* was supported ($\beta = -0.395$, $p = 0.0001$), indicating that perceived equities in pay and incentives significantly reduced voluntary turnover intention.

(2) H3 *("reward and recognition")* was supported ($\beta = -0.282$, $p = 0.0003$), affirming the role of fair recognition practices in reducing voluntary turnover intention.

(3) H9 *("training and continuous education")* was supported ($\beta = -0.356$, $p = 0.0002$), suggesting that opportunities for professional development lowered voluntary turnover intention.

(4) H4 *("organizational culture")* was not supported ($\beta = 0.105$, $p = 0.115$), implying that perceptions of organizational culture did not significantly influence voluntary turnover intention during the study period.

(5) H6 *("relationship with supervisor")* was not supported ($\beta = 0.100$, $p = 0.163$), indicating that supervisory relationships were not a significant factor in voluntary turnover decisions at this stage.

Thus, "pay and incentives", "reward and recognition", and "training and continuous education" emerged as the strongest predictors of voluntary turnover intention post the first phase of analysis. Organizational fit and relational factors were comparatively less influential during the initial post-pandemic "great resignation" period.

Table 3. Hypotheses test (Phase 1)

Hypothesis		β	Sig.	Result
H2	There is a negative relationship between perceived equities in pay and incentives and voluntary turnover intention	−0.395	0.0001	Supported
H3	There is a negative relationship between perceived fairness in reward and recognition and voluntary turnover intention	−0.282	0.0003	Supported
H4	There is a negative relationship between positive perceptions of organizational culture and voluntary turnover intention	0.105	0.115	Not supported
H6	There is a negative relationship between perceived positive employee-supervisor relationship and voluntary turnover intention	0.100	0.163	Not supported
H9	There is a negative relationship between perceived greater opportunities for training and continuous education and voluntary turnover intention	−0.356	0.0002	Supported

Source(s): Authors' own work

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4.3 Phase 2: text mining analysis of HR managers' perspectives

Based on the responses, the HR managers consistently highlighted the following themes:

(1) *Boss-subordinate relationship*: The professional relationship with immediate supervisors was frequently cited as a critical factor influencing voluntary turnover decisions.

(2) *Nature of work*: Factors such as task variety, degree of challenge, and autonomy in executing work were emphasized.

(3) *Reward and recognition*: The availability of promotion avenues, pay packages, and non-monetary recognition were seen as major determinants of employee satisfaction and retention.

Text mining analysis confirmed the qualitative insights provided by the HR managers. Frequency analysis (Figure 1) highlighted that "nature of work", "autonomy", "recognition", "supervisor relationship", "reward", and "organizational culture" were the most frequently mentioned concepts. These terms correspond closely to relational and environmental aspects of the work experience, suggesting that HR managers attributed voluntary turnover not to financial factors but to the quality of interpersonal interactions and job design.

A word cloud (Figure 2), generated from the interview transcripts, further illustrated these findings. The prominence of "nature of work", "supervisor", "organizational culture", and "recognition" depicted a strong managerial belief that voluntary turnover stems from a lack of emotional engagement and alignment with job roles. Notably, terms like "job prestige", "motivation", and "autonomy" emerged clearly, indicating that HR managers viewed job enrichment as a critical retention lever.

However, this was in contrast to the employee data results from phase 1 where tangible and extrinsic factors such as "pay", "training", and "reward" were more predictive of voluntary turnover. This perceptual gap underlined the need for more aligned interventions.

4.4 Categorization of turnover predictors and design of interventions

Following the completion of phase 1 and phase 2, the voluntary turnover predictors identified were systematically classified into push, pull, and mooring factors using the PPM framework.

Based on the data, key push factors included lack of reward and recognition, unsatisfactory relationships with supervisors, and perceptions of stagnant organizational culture. Prominent pull factors identified included better financial incentives and enhanced training and career development opportunities elsewhere, especially in the highly competitive IT and ITeS sectors.

Mooring factors referred to personal, psychological, or contextual elements that could go either way to inhibit or facilitate voluntary turnover intention. In this study, nature of work, job

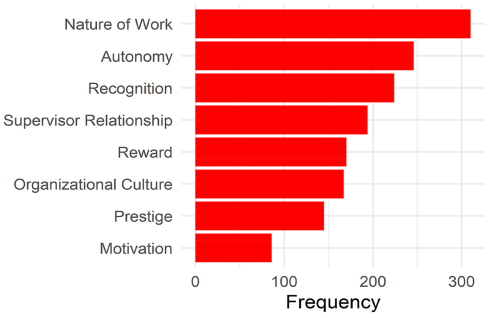


Figure 1. Frequency analysis of dominant constructs. **Source:** Authors' own work

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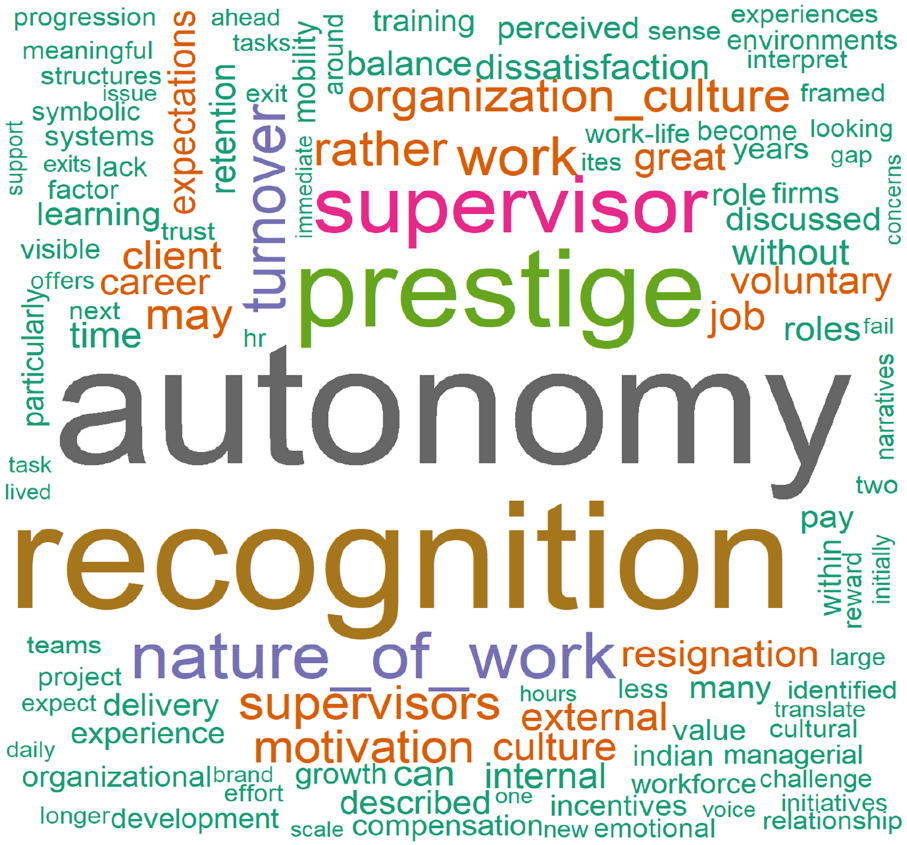


Figure 2. Word cloud based on HR managers' text responses. **Source:** Authors' own work

prestige, work-life balance, and job autonomy were categorized as mooring factors, reflecting the degree to which employees felt attached to their roles and organizations.

The categorization exercise (Figure 3) synthesized quantitative (phase 1 and phase 3) and qualitative (phase 2) findings by classifying identified predictors into push, pull, and mooring factors influencing voluntary turnover intention. Push and pull factors were empirically tested in regression models (Tables 3 and 4), while mooring factors emerged prominently in qualitative analysis (Figure 2), highlighting perceptual differences between employees and HR managers. While employees prioritized tangible and developmental pull factors (e.g. compensation and skill enhancement), HR managers placed greater emphasis on relational and cultural push factors (e.g. supervisor relationships and work environment).

Based on this categorization, a set of targeted pilot interventions was designed to address the dominant push and pull factors while strengthening positive mooring forces. The intervention strategy emphasized:

(1) Rotational onsite assignments: To address pull factors related to better career development and financial incentives, employers were asked to offer opportunities for international or client-site projects. These assignments would enhance employees' skill sets and provide financial benefits, thereby reducing the allure of external job opportunities. Rotational onsite assignments were operationalized through short-term

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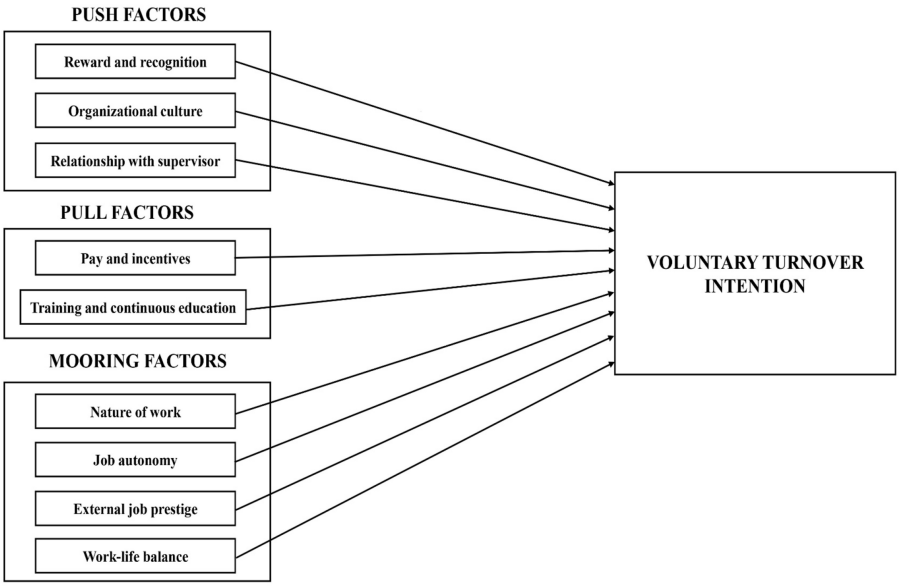


Figure 3. Conceptual categorization of voluntary turnover predictors using the PPM framework. **Source:** Authors' own work

Table 4. Hypotheses test (Phase 3)

Hypothesis		β	Sig.	Result
H2	There is a negative relationship between perceived equities in pay and incentives and voluntary turnover intention	−0.509	0.0001	Supported
H3	There is a negative relationship between perceived fairness in reward and recognition and voluntary turnover intention	−0.163	0.0003	Supported
H4	There is a negative relationship between positive perceptions of organizational culture and voluntary turnover intention	−0.052	0.212	Not supported
H6	There is a negative relationship between perceived positive employee-supervisor relationship and voluntary turnover intention	−0.228	0.0004	Supported
H9	There is a negative relationship between perceived greater opportunities for training and continuous education and voluntary turnover intention	−0.369	0.0002	Supported

Source(s): Authors' own work

client-facing or cross-functional project deployments for eligible employees, thereby combining skill enhancement with financial incentives.

(2) Managerial training programmes: To mitigate key push factors, employers were suggested to lay greater emphasis on supervisor-employee relationships. The managerial training programmes consisted of structured 2–3 h workshop sessions conducted virtually, focusing on transformational leadership behaviors, feedback delivery techniques, active listening practices, and team engagement strategies. These sessions were facilitated internally by HR learning and development units, using standardized training modules and discussion-based case illustrations.

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(3) Recognition and reward programmes: Firms were asked to ensure timely and meaningful recognition of employee contributions. Any dissatisfaction was to be catered to with absolute transparency and proper explanations. Recognition and reward initiatives involved formalizing monthly and quarterly appreciation mechanisms, including publicly acknowledging employee contributions during team meetings, implementing peer-recognition channels, and providing transparent communication regarding performance-linked incentives. The emphasis was placed on consistency, visibility, and clarity of criteria rather than introducing entirely new reward structures.

(4) Work-life balance flexibility: Organizations were nudged to continue with some sort of flexible work arrangements post the pandemic and not do away with the "work from home" policy entirely. Work–life balance flexibility was maintained through hybrid scheduling options and continued work-from-home provisions where operationally feasible. This would strengthen the positive mooring factors and improve perceptions of organizational support for personal well-being.

Following careful stakeholder consultation, a pilot implementation of the proposed interventions was undertaken within participating units beginning in March 2023. Their effectiveness was assessed during phase 3 through a longitudinal follow-up survey with employees to evaluate the changes in voluntary turnover intention and the salience of categorized predictors.

4.5 Phase 3: longitudinal assessment and hypotheses testing

The multiple regression model for phase 3 demonstrated good fit statistics. The model achieved $R = 0.816$, $R^2 = 0.666$, and an Adjusted R^2 of 0.658, indicating that approximately 65.8% of the variance in voluntary turnover intention could now be explained by the predictors. This was an improvement compared to the phase 1 results, suggesting that the interventions had a measurable impact on voluntary turnover predictors.

The results of hypotheses testing in phase 3 are summarized in Table 4.

To facilitate clearer interpretation of longitudinal shifts, standardized beta coefficients from phase 1 and phase 3 were compared directly to assess changes in relative predictor strength. Table 5 presents a side-by-side comparison of standardized coefficients across both phases. The standardized coefficient comparison demonstrates not merely persistence but redistribution of predictive weight across phases, reinforcing the temporal elasticity of PPM forces. This side-by-side comparison provides empirical support for the dynamic recalibration of push and pull forces over time rather than a static predictor structure.

Table 5. Standardized β comparison across Phase 1 and Phase 3

Predictor	Phase 1 β	Phase 3 β	Direction of change
Pay and incentives (PIN)	−0.395	−0.509	Increased
Reward and recognition (RG)	−0.282	−0.163	Decreased
Training and continuous education (TCE)	−0.356	−0.369	Stable
Organizational culture (OGC)	0.105 (non-significant)	−0.052 (non-significant)	Non-significant
Relationship with supervisor (ERS)	0.100 (non-significant)	−0.228	Activated

Source(s): Authors' own work

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Key observations include:

(1) H2 *("pay and incentives")* remained a strong predictor ($\beta = -0.509$, $p = 0.0001$), with the absolute value of the coefficient increasing significantly from phase 1. This indicated that enhanced financial incentives (such as through onsite assignments) became an even stronger determinant of voluntary turnover reduction.

(2) H3 *("reward and recognition")* continued to be supported ($\beta = -0.163$, $p = 0.0003$), although the effect size nearly halved as compared to phase 1. This suggests that, after addressing immediate dissatisfaction, employees increasingly prioritized more tangible career advancement and financial incentives over symbolic forms of appreciation.

(3) H9 *("training and continuous education")* also remained significant ($\beta = -0.369$, $p = 0.0002$), reinforcing the importance of continuous professional development.

(4) H4 *("organizational culture")* remained non-significant ($\beta = -0.052$, $p = 0.212$), implying that deep-rooted cultural changes may require longer timelines to manifest measurable impacts.

(5) H6 *("relationship with supervisor")*, which was not significant in phase 1, became statistically significant in phase 3 ($\beta = -0.228$, $p = 0.0004$). This shift suggests that the managerial training interventions positively influenced employee perceptions regarding supervisory relationships.

4.6 Robustness and diagnostic checks (phase 1 and phase 3)

To ensure the stability and validity of the findings across both the quantitative phases, multiple diagnostic and robustness procedures were conducted.

4.6.1 Common method bias. Given the self-reported nature of survey data, Harman's single-factor test was employed as a preliminary diagnostic for common method variance on the phase 1 EFA dataset containing the 21 retained items. The first unrotated factor accounted for 11.84% of total variance. The value was substantially below the conservative 50% threshold commonly used to indicate potential common method bias (Podsakoff *et al.*, 2003), suggesting that common method variance is unlikely to threaten the validity of the results.

4.6.2 Multicollinearity. Variance inflation factors (VIF) were calculated to assess multicollinearity (Hair *et al.*, 2019a).

Phase 1 VIF range: 1.18–1.33

Phase 3 VIF range: 1.04–1.24

All values were well below the conservative threshold of 5 (Hair *et al.*, 2019a). Additionally, full collinearity VIFs were computed to assess potential lateral collinearity and method bias.

Phase 1 full VIF range: 1.14–2.15

Phase 3 full VIF range: 1.04–2.97

All values were below the recommended 3.3 cut-off (Kock, 2015), indicating no multicollinearity or common method concerns.

4.6.3 Heteroscedasticity. Heteroscedasticity was assessed using the Breusch–Pagan test (Breusch and Pagan, 1979) and White's general test (White, 1980). For both phase 1 and phase 3: Breusch–Pagan tests were non-significant ($p > 0.05$) and White tests were non-significant ($p > 0.05$). These findings indicated homoscedastic residuals and no violation of regression assumptions.

4.6.4 Robust regression and robust standard errors. To ensure that results were not driven by outliers or non-normal residual distributions, M-estimation robust regression was conducted using the Huber weighting procedure (Huber, 1964). Across both phases, coefficient magnitudes and significance levels remained substantively unchanged.

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Additionally, heteroskedasticity-consistent (HC3) robust standard errors were computed (Long and Ervin, 2000). The significance patterns remained stable, further supporting the robustness of the regression findings.

4.6.5 Sensitivity analyses. Sensitivity checks were conducted in both phases:

(1) To examine the robustness of the estimated effects, alternative model specifications were estimated across both phase 1 and phase 3, including a parsimonious model retaining only the statistically significant predictors. Consistent with recommendations for specification robustness testing in regression analysis (Greene, 2018; Long and Ervin, 2000), coefficient signs, magnitudes, and statistical significance were compared across models. The substantive interpretation of results remained unchanged across specifications.

(2) Standardized beta coefficients were computed to assess the relative magnitude of predictors and confirm effect-size stability (Aiken and West, 1991; Hair *et al.*, 2019a). The ordering and substantive interpretation of predictors remained unchanged across phases, reinforcing comparative conclusions regarding predictor salience.

(3) Predictors were mean-centered to evaluate potential collinearity distortions and intercept instability (Aiken and West, 1991). Coefficient magnitudes and statistical significance remained unaffected in both phases, indicating that the results were robust to scaling adjustments.

5. Discussion

5.1 Interpretation of expected results

"Pay and incentives": Across phases, "pay and incentives" remained the most influential predictor of voluntary turnover intention, with its predictive strength intensifying following the interventions. This outcome indicates that financial considerations are not static hygiene factors but dynamic levers that respond positively to strategic enhancements. The increase in predictive power after the interventions aligns with Herzberg's dual-factor theory (House and Wigdor, 1967), suggesting that when employees experience meaningful financial and developmental gains, their organizational attachment is significantly strengthened.

"Reward and recognition": Although "reward and recognition" remained significant, a notable decline in effect size suggested shifting employee priorities. Post-crisis environments, such as the aftermath of the "great resignation", recalibrated employee expectations towards security, skill acquisition, career mobility, and tangible advancement opportunities. This result is consistent with research indicating that in volatile employment markets, symbolic rewards lose their motivational potency relative to material gains (Rai *et al.*, 2019).

"Training and continuous education": Sustained significance of training and continuous education opportunities highlights the salience of employability security, whereby employees assess organizational value based on its ability to enhance future career prospects (De Cuyper and De Witte, 2011). Given the advent of AI and rapid technological evolution within the IT sector, continuous skill upgradation has emerged as a critical retention lever, reaffirming the investment logic behind human capital theory (Becker, 1964).

Taken together, these results indicate that voluntary turnover intention during post-crisis periods was not governed by static predictors but by a shifting equilibrium between push, pull, and mooring forces. In phase 1, pull factors dominated decision-making, reflecting heightened market sensitivity during the immediate aftermath of the "great resignation". Following targeted interventions, phase 3 results suggested partial recalibration of this balance. While pull forces remained strong, relational push factors such as employee–supervisor relationships gained significance. This indicated a re-stabilization of internal attachment mechanisms once immediate instrumental concerns were addressed. This dynamic shift supports the view that turnover predictors operate as interacting forces rather than isolated variables.

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5.2 Contradictions and unexpected results

While several findings were consistent with prior research and theoretical expectations, two notable contradictions and unexpected results merit deeper exploration.

5.2.1 Non-significance of "organizational culture". Despite its strong theoretical grounding in models of job embeddedness (Mitchell *et al.*, 2001) and person-organization fit theory (Kristof-Brown *et al.*, 2005), organizational culture did not appear as a statistically significant predictor of voluntary turnover intention in either phase 1 or phase 3. This is particularly surprising given the emphasis placed by HR managers on organizational culture during qualitative interviews in phase 2.

Several explanations may account for this discrepancy:

(1) *Temporal limitation:* Organizational culture, by nature, represents deep-rooted assumptions and shared meanings (Schein, 2010). Such foundational elements typically require long periods of sustained effort to evolve. Given that the interventions focused primarily on relatively quick wins, it is plausible that the short intervention window was insufficient to produce perceptible shifts in cultural alignment from the employees' perspective.

(2) *Hierarchy of needs in crisis periods:* Following major disruptions like the COVID-19 pandemic and the "great resignation", employees may have temporarily prioritized transactional needs (e.g. financial rewards, career security) over transformational needs (e.g. cultural congruence or identity fulfilment). This echoes Maslow's hierarchy of needs, where survival and security needs must be satisfied before higher-order needs become salient.

(3) *Misalignment of managerial and employee perceptions:* The qualitative findings indicated that HR managers emphasized culture, but employees were more focused on tangible career and compensation factors. This misalignment may have diluted the effect of cultural interventions.

Thus, while organizational culture remains theoretically important, its influence may be temporally muted during high-uncertainty periods, requiring longitudinal examination beyond the immediate aftermath of interventions.

5.2.2 Emergence of "relationship with supervisor" as a significant predictor. Another unexpected finding was the emergence of "relationship with supervisor" as a significant predictor in phase 3, whereas it was non-significant in phase 1.

This reversal suggests several important dynamics:

(1) *Relational interventions are highly elastic:* Unlike deep-seated organizational cultural norms, relational behaviours — such as providing feedback, empowering employees, or showing individualized consideration — can change relatively quickly through targeted managerial training (Graen and Uhl-Bien, 1995). The managerial interventions introduced after phase 2 likely had a tangible and immediate impact on employees' day-to-day experiences with their supervisors.

(2) *Trust-building during organizational uncertainty:* In post-crisis environments, employees may seek psychological safety and stability. Here, supervisor support becomes a critical anchor. The significance of supervisor relationships post-intervention validates theories of social exchange (Blau, 1964) and affective commitment (Meyer and Allen, 1991), where relational contracts take precedence when formal structures feel volatile.

(3) *Delayed salience:* It is also possible that, initially, employees were too focused on immediate financial and job security needs to value relational quality. As those more pressing needs were addressed, relational factors gained visibility in shaping long-term retention considerations.

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Thus, the latent importance of supervisor relationships surfaced only after foundational financial and developmental needs were sufficiently met. This uncovered a hierarchical unfolding of voluntary turnover predictors, an aspect that few turnover models currently accommodate explicitly.

5.3 Theoretical contributions

This study advances theoretical understanding in several important ways:

First, it integrates the PPM framework into the context of systemic labour market disruptions, such as the "great resignation" phenomenon. While the PPM model has traditionally been applied to stable organizational environments, this study shows that under conditions of macroeconomic uncertainty, the balance between push, pull, and mooring forces can shift dynamically. The results demonstrate that during periods of turbulence, pull factors exert greater influence over voluntary turnover intention than mooring factors, suggesting a temporary reordering of employee priorities. This insight refines existing turnover models by emphasizing their temporal sensitivity and responsiveness to broader socio-economic shocks.

Second, the study nuances job embeddedness theory by revealing that in highly dynamic and technology-driven industries like IT, fit and sacrifice components (career growth opportunities and financial incentives) dominate over linkage components (relational ties with supervisors and organizational culture) during disruptive periods. This finding challenges the assumption of static dominance among embeddedness dimensions, highlighting that the relative salience of fit, links, and sacrifice is contingent on the broader socio-economic climate. It calls for a more contextualized and temporally grounded application of job embeddedness theory in future research.

Third, the study offers a dual-stakeholder perspective on voluntary turnover predictors by juxtaposing employee self-perceptions with HR managers' interpretations. Prior research has largely focused either on employee reports or organizational viewpoints in isolation. By comparing these narratives, the study identifies significant perceptual gaps between frontline employees and HR practitioners. This adds theoretical depth to turnover studies by emphasizing the role of interpretive misalignment in shaping ineffective retention strategies. It advances the field's understanding of how subjective framings from different stakeholders influence organizational outcomes.

Fourth, the longitudinal research design provides rare empirical evidence regarding the efficacy of targeted interventions in reshaping turnover predictors. By tracking employee responses before and after the implementation of strategic interventions, the study empirically validates how proactive organizational adjustments can re-balance push, pull, and mooring factors. This interventionist approach enriches the turnover literature, which often treats predictors as static variables rather than modifiable organizational levers.

Fifth, it broadens the theorization of turnover beyond Western contexts. Much of existing turnover research is situated in Western economies, often neglecting collectivistic, fast-growing economies such as India. By demonstrating the dominance of instrumental factors even in an Indian context - traditionally associated with relational loyalty and collectivistic norms - the study questions the presumed universality of certain cultural assumptions embedded in turnover theories. It thus contributes to the growing call for greater cultural sensitivity and contextual variability in organizational behaviour research.

Finally, the study conceptually frames turnover during the "great resignation" era as a manifestation of career self-management behaviour, wherein employees, empowered by expanded labour market fluidity, actively recalibrated their professional trajectories. This extends psychological contract theory by illustrating how macro disruptions can rapidly alter employee expectations of the employer-employee relationship.

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5.4 Managerial implications

The findings of this study collectively suggest that retention strategies must evolve in tandem with the dominant mobility forces operating at a given time. When pull pressures dominate, organizations must respond with tangible value propositions; when relational forces regain salience, leadership quality and embeddedness mechanisms become critical stabilizers. Thus, the findings carry important and actionable implications for practitioners preparing for the anticipated "great resignation 2.0".

First, organizations must prioritize tangible, career-enhancing opportunities. The study shows that during systemic disruptions, employees value pull factors such as financial incentives and skill development opportunities more than relational or cultural ties. As such, companies must proactively offer structured rotational programmes, international assignments, client-site projects, and internal mobility tracks that not only provide financial rewards but also enhance employees' professional portfolios. Static roles without visible growth pathways will accelerate voluntary turnover during the forthcoming labour market churn.

Second, HR leaders must view financial incentives as strategic investments rather than transactional costs. The significant increase in the predictive power of "pay and incentives" between phases highlights that compensation structures must be dynamic and market-responsive. Organizations must adopt real-time salary benchmarking, targeted retention bonuses, and personalized incentive plans to neutralize external pull forces. Ignoring pay competitiveness will expose organizations to a rapid loss of critical talent in the next upheaval.

Third, training and continuous education initiatives must be repositioned from "optional benefits" to "strategic imperatives". Given that training and development remained a consistent and powerful turnover predictor, firms should institutionalize personalized learning roadmaps, integrate certification programmes, and ensure budget allocations for professional growth. Companies that invest in visible, employee-driven skill enhancement will be better insulated against widespread voluntary turnover.

Fourth, relational management practices must be recalibrated. The emergence of "relationship with supervisor" as a significant predictor post-intervention underscores the importance of frontline leadership quality. Managers must be trained in transformational leadership, empathy-driven management, and conflict-resolution techniques. Organizations should institutionalize 360-degree feedback mechanisms and continuous coaching models rather than relying solely on annual appraisals.

Fifth, organizations must recognize that "cultural interventions" have a long gestation period. Despite managerial efforts, organizational culture can remain a non-significant predictor of short-term turnover reduction. Therefore, immediate retention efforts should focus on instrumental motivators, while culture-building should proceed as a parallel long-term project.

Finally, firms must prioritize mental health and emotional resilience as core retention strategies. Large-scale disruptions - like the COVID-19 pandemic - can impact employees' mental health, leading to increased burnout, anxiety, and emotional fatigue. These psychosocial stresses often accumulate silently and contribute to delayed but massive turnover waves. As organizations brace for the "great resignation 2.0", it is critical to proactively invest in mental health initiatives, resilience-building programmes, and emotional well-being frameworks. Companies must normalize conversations around mental health, offer professional counseling services, promote mental health leave policies, and train managers to detect early signs of emotional distress. Creating psychologically safe environments where employees feel genuinely supported will serve as a critical mooring force, reducing the psychological push factors that often precede mass voluntary exits.

5.5 Societal implications

Beyond organizational-level outcomes, the findings of this study carry broader societal implications, particularly in the context of post-pandemic workforce restructuring and anticipated labour market volatility.

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First, the dominance of instrumental pull factors such as pay, career mobility, and skill development reflects a deeper psychological recalibration among employees. Periods of systemic disruption, such as the COVID-19 aftermath and the "great resignation" have heightened concerns related to economic security, employability, and long-term career resilience. When these needs remain unmet, employees experience heightened uncertainty, stress, and disengagement. Thus, voluntary turnover cannot be viewed solely as an organizational metric; it is also an indicator of psychological well-being and perceived future stability.

Second, the emergence of relational factors (e.g. supervisor support) as significant only after instrumental needs were partially addressed underscores the layered nature of work–life integration. In hybrid and digitally mediated work environments, employees increasingly seek autonomy, flexibility, and meaningful supervisory engagement. These elements function not merely as retention levers but as mechanisms supporting mental health, emotional stability, and sustainable productivity.

Third, voluntary turnover imposes substantial economic costs beyond individual organizations. High attrition in knowledge-intensive sectors such as IT contributes to productivity loss, skill drain, and increased labour market friction. At a macro level, repeated cycles of rapid hiring and mass exit can distort wage structures, inflate recruitment costs, and destabilize talent pipelines. Therefore, understanding turnover predictors contributes to broader economic sustainability by informing policies that promote workforce stability.

Finally, the study highlights the importance of building sustainable workforce ecosystems rather than relying solely on transactional retention strategies. Sustainable ecosystems require alignment between organizational incentives, employee development pathways, relational leadership practices, and psychosocial support systems. In the absence of such alignment, labour markets may experience recurring waves of mobility triggered by external shocks.

Taken together, these findings suggest that preparing for a potential "great resignation 2.0" is not merely a strategic HR concern but a societal imperative involving psychological well-being, economic resilience, and sustainable employment structures.

6. Limitations and agenda for future research

Despite its contributions, the study has limitations that should be acknowledged to inform future research endeavours.

First, while the longitudinal design allowed for tracking changes over time, the follow-up period was limited to one year. Organizational culture shifts and relational dynamics often require longer timeframes to manifest measurable impacts. Future research could extend the longitudinal horizon to two or more years to capture delayed or gradual changes in voluntary turnover predictors.

Second, the study focused on employees within Indian IT and allied knowledge-based sectors. Although this sector is emblematic of fast-changing, high-skill environments, the findings may not fully generalize to other industries, geographies, or cultural contexts. Future studies should replicate and extend this framework to manufacturing sectors, public services, and non-IT knowledge sectors, both within India and across global markets, to test for contextual variability.

Third, the research categorized voluntary turnover predictors into push, pull, and mooring forces using the PPM framework. However, the dynamic interactions among these forces — how, for instance, a weakening mooring force may amplify a pull factor — were not explicitly modelled. Future research could explore interactive and moderating effects between different categories of predictors to better capture the complexity of voluntary turnover decision-making processes.

Fourth, the study implicitly assumes that all voluntary turnover is dysfunctional. However, voluntary mobility can sometimes refresh organizational capabilities or enable better person-organization fit elsewhere. Future investigations could differentiate between functional and dysfunctional voluntary turnover to refine retention strategies accordingly.

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Fifth, EFA led to the exclusion of certain theoretically grounded constructs (e.g. nature of work, job autonomy, external job prestige, and work–life balance). Although these constructs were conceptually robust and supported by prior literature, they did not demonstrate sufficient loading strength within the specific empirical context of this study. One plausible explanation is that during the immediate post-pandemic recalibration period, employees prioritized instrumental and developmental factors over experiential or identity-related dimensions. In high-volatility labour market conditions, tangible economic and career considerations may temporarily overshadow job design or prestige-related attributes. Future research should re-examine these constructs in more stabilized labour environments or test them using confirmatory approaches to determine whether their salience is context-dependent or temporally sensitive.

Finally, the impending "great resignation 2.0" will likely unfold under the influence of additional macro-forces such as AI-driven work transformations, hybrid work models, and shifting generational expectations. Future longitudinal studies should factor in these evolving structural drivers to maintain relevance in a rapidly changing employment landscape.

7. Conclusion

The study reveals a temporary reconfiguration of voluntary turnover predictors during periods of systemic disruption, where individualistic and instrumental concerns supersede relational embeddedness. Employees tend to prioritize tangible, self-advancing factors such as compensation, skill development, and career progression over traditionally stabilizing relational elements like organizational culture and supervisor relationships. This shift reflects an adaptive recalibration of priorities, wherein immediate professional security and future career resilience outweigh relational investments within current organizations.

These findings underscore the dynamic and context-sensitive nature of voluntary turnover predictors, particularly in the aftermath of systemic shocks. As the labour market anticipates the forthcoming "great resignation 2.0", it becomes evident that retention strategies must evolve accordingly. Organizations must recognize that fostering employee loyalty under such volatile conditions depends less on reinforcing traditional relational attachments and more on offering individualized, tangible value propositions — including competitive financial incentives, robust learning pathways, and visible career advancement opportunities.

Consequently, retention frameworks must remain agile and capable of responding to shifting employee expectations without relying solely on cultural engagement levers. By embracing a flexible, employee-centric approach, organizations can better navigate workforce volatility and build resilient, future-ready talent ecosystems.

Data availability statement

Research data not shared due to privacy concerns.

Informed consent

The authors acquired the informed consent of all the participants approached for the purpose of data collection for this article.

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Supplementary material

The supplementary material for this article can be found online.

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